

WiFi enabled phones satisfy

Survey by ABI Research shows that 77 per cent of users of WiFi enabled handsets are fully satisfied with their devices

Wi-Fi test

be assigned to different bands and there is double the theoretical bandwidth available. Sadly, this device had no bundled stand; we found that adding a stand boosted signal strength in zone 1, 2 and 3 by 17, 6 and 3 per cent respectively.

The Netgear WRT610N was another stunner. It looks like something Darth Vader would wear and has a dark blue outer bezel with the entire body finished in glossy black. A USB port has been provided along with the RJ45 ports and any storage device connected means you have a ready multimedia server that can be accessed both from within the network or even over the internet. This is also a dual simultaneous band router and the firmware is replete with options and settings, advanced users will have a field day. The Linksys WRT310N and WRT160N also share the same shape as the WRT610N and its sterling build quality but are slightly smaller in terms of their footprint. Since these routers all have internal antennas they do not have stands and are meant to be placed flat atop a table or wall mounted. The WRT310N has a silver outer bezel, while the WRT160N is totally black. The WRT310N supports 256-bit SPI firewall, while the WRT160N has regular 128-bit SPI. Once again the firmware features are rich with a lot of options and the menus, although replete with advanced settings are pretty intuitive.

Buffalo's WHR-G300N is a super-slim router with a sleek stand, although removing the stand after inserting it is a pain and you can actually see the two sides of the routers fibre bezel move apart to free the tines of the stand. Other than this build quality is very good and the firmware interface is intuitive and easy to work around being less technical than Linksys' interface. Belkins N1 Vision

was really something else. This MIMO supporting router is built very well and skips the activity LEDs for a monochrome LCD display that is very useful and not just a cosmetic add-on. Not only can you change quite a few settings here via the soft, rubberised buttons but one can also view the connection status, connected clients and even check on the quantity of data uploaded and downloaded – ultra neat. The matte silver body and glossy black fascia are certainly attractive and the overall effect is classy. The firmware interface shared by the other two Belkin routers is intuitive with sufficient settings and clearly designed with the newbie in mind. Like the other Draft N and some 802.11G routers from Netgear and Linksys, Dlink and Buffalo this one supports DMZ.

Performance

When it came to raw throughput and our gruelling real-world transfer tests three routers stood head and shoulders above the rest – Linksys' WRT610N and WRT310N and Netgear's WNR2000. Trailing a bit behind was Linksys' own WRT160N. In fact the scores in zone 3 surprised us – both the WRT610N and the WRT310N managed over 2 MBps in the sequential transfers and well over one megabyte per second in the assorted transfer – super stuff. When it came

to video streaming though the Netgear WNR2000 ate them for breakfast and while the performance gap wasn't very great it was noticeable enough. Buffalo's WHR-G300N also performed well in zone 1 and 2 but performance dropped off in zone 3, this bespeaks a slightly weaker antenna. Dlinks DIR-655 was the fastest performer when it came to sequential transfers in zone 1 – it crossed the magic 5 MBps mark. Netgear's WNR3300 is also pretty fast and although it cannot trail with the quickest it does manage to hold its own with good scores in zone 1 and zone 2 that trail off in zone 3. The missing stand

really hurts this Netgear product and we hope retail versions of this router ship with a stand for desktop use. Belkins N1 Vision did well overall and beat its cheaper sibling, the Wireless N Router by a fair margin. Sadly most of the 802.11G routers get left behind no doubt due to their lower maximum throughput. One revelation post test was that none of the Draft N routers are as fast as the 802.11N specification claims they should be. A mere 40 MBps is a poor score for a standard that is supposed to deliver 600 MBps. And these devices are nowhere close to even half this figure.

Conclusion Up to Rs. 5,000

Belkins Wireless G Router took our Best Buy award. It's not particularly fast, but will get you through all but the most bandwidth intensive operations. It's built well, if simply and at a price of Rs.



Netgear WNR2000

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